CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Wednesday, November 11, 2026 No. 231 13 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Naenara published the full text of the March 2026 revised DPRK constitution, formalizing Kim Jong Un's expanded powers and the two-state territorial definition.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,375.36	1,334.13	$92.65	39%	Nov 8	3.00%
+2.6%	−0.7%	+1.3%	flat Oct 27-29	3 days ago	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

SBS / NK News, DPRK

North Korea fires two ballistic missiles from Muncheon; Naenara publishes revised constitution text

North Korea launched two ballistic missiles from Muncheon into the East Sea on Nov 11, with a flight distance of approximately 350 km, according to JTBC and Yonhap reporting.

Separately, North Korea's official web portal Naenara published the full text of the constitution amended by the Supreme People's Assembly on March 23, 2026, formalizing **Kim Jong Un**'s expanded authority and the country's redefinition of its territory to exclude the South, the first time the constitution section had been restored to the portal since North Korea pledged to rewrite the document in early 2024, per NK News. The launch is the latest in a series of weapons tests over the past week, all of which have been kept off the domestic news agenda.

Foreign Ministry, US-Korea, Primary

FM Cho Hyun meets SecState Rubio on G7 sidelines; agrees to advance Lee-Trump summit agreements

ROK Foreign Minister **Cho Hyun** held a bilateral meeting with US Secretary of State **Marco Rubio** on Nov 10 on the sidelines of the G7 Foreign Ministers' Meeting in Paris, exchanging views on overall bilateral relations, high-level exchanges, and North Korea, according to MOFA. Rubio separately noted at a press conference that South Korea was among the partners invited to the G7 meeting.

02 | OVERNIGHT

The Korea Herald, US-Korea

FM Cho stresses mutual respect as prerequisite in first face-to-face talks with Ukrainian FM Sybiha

First in-person meeting since the North Korean POW disclosure dispute erupted in September.

Bloomberg, ROK Economy

South Korea's jobless rate hits 3-year low despite weak hiring

Labor market tightening persists even as overall hiring momentum slows.

WSJ, ROK Economy

South Korea inflation remained above target in October

Above-target CPI in October constrains BOK room for near-term rate cuts.

Yonhap, NK-Russia-China

Russian youth delegation conducts historical tour in Pyongyang

People-to-people exchanges expanding as Russian visits to North Korea rise through 2026.

Yonhap News Agency, US-Korea

JCS Chairman Gen. Jin Yong-sung flies KF-21, inspects Korea Air and Missile Defense readiness

Called KAMD a 'core asset' of the three-axis deterrence system; ordered around-the-clock early warning posture.

Bloomberg, ROK Economy

Turkey nears new nuclear power deal, favors Canada and South Korea

Seoul's bid for Turkish nuclear plant contract advances as Bloomberg reports Turkey narrows shortlist.

Reuters, ROK Politics

Ukrainian FM says ties with South Korea on the road to improvement after Paris meeting

Ukrainian Foreign Minister Sybiha signaled forward movement after bilateral talks with Cho on Nov 10 addressed the POW disclosure dispute.

Daily NK, DPRK

North Korea transfers AI specialists from Reconnaissance General Bureau to Foreign Ministry

Late-October transfers stirred resentment inside the spy agency that spent years developing the cadre.

03 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

No public appearance today, last seen 3 days ago

No KCNA watch flag. 6 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

Daily NK

DPRK intelligence officer in China privately concedes North Korea carried out the $6.3 billion Binance hack, contradicting Kim Yo Jong's public denials

A North Korean Reconnaissance and Intelligence General Bureau officer based in Liaoning Province told a Daily NK source he believes his own country carried out the November 2026 Binance cryptocurrency heist, directly contradicting Kim Yo Jong's repeated public denials.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Yo Jong, Vice Director, Korean Workers' Party Central Committee

Kim Yo Jong rejected UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres's call for inter-Korean dialogue after the DMZ landmine incident, accusing him of siding with Seoul, per Reuters and Yonhap citing KCNA, as reported Nov 10 and carried over in today's feeds.

> **Bottom line:** State media confirmed the publication of the revised constitution's full text formalizing Kim's expanded powers and the two-state framework, while the North Korean ballistic missile launches from Muncheon remain absent from domestic KCNA output.

04 ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Wednesday, November 11, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

FM Cho Hyun

MOFA hosts 8th Action with Women and Peace international conference in Seoul

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs convened the 8th Action with Women and Peace international conference at the Grand Lotte Seoul hotel on Nov 11, bringing together international organization representatives, academics, and civil society experts to discuss Women, Peace and Security innovation including AI applications. The initiative has been run by MOFA since 2019.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF UNIFICATION

Unification Minister Chung Dong-young

Unification Minister describes North Korea's military provocations as 'signals' toward dialogue

Unification Minister **Chung Dong-young** stated that North Korea's military demonstrations are also signals directed at South Korea, and that reducing hostility is the core of the Lee government's peace policy. He said easing adversarial relations must come first before substantive dialogue can be pursued.

Source Segye Ilbo

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Assembly Speaker Cho Jeong-sik outlines constitutional amendment framework excluding current president from re-election

National Assembly Speaker

National Assembly Speaker **Cho Jeong-sik** stated that barring the current president from re-election is a core principle of a sovereignty-based constitutional amendment, and that 2027, a year without scheduled elections, would be an appropriate and calm time to pursue revision, per Hankyoreh and other outlets.

05 US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232 authority. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24 2026, leaving no single baseline reciprocal tariff. Section 301 investigations launched March 11 2026 against South Korea and 15 other trading partners are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

06 | CAPITOL HILL

VOA, Legislation

Lame-duck Congress opens; National Defense Authorization Act, North Korea bills, and committee chair changes on agenda

The lame-duck session of Congress has opened with the National Defense Authorization Act, North Korea-related bills, and committee chair transitions all in play as Democrats prepare to assume majority control in January, per VOA Korean.

The Korea Herald, House, Statement

House Republicans quash effort to impeach Defense Secretary Hegseth

House Republicans blocked a Democratic effort to impeach Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth; Hegseth stated the impeachment attempt was a 'political show' and that he fully supports Trump's military operations, per Korea Herald.

news.sbs.co.kr, Statement

Expert: Democratic control of Congress could slow South Korea's investments in the United States

An expert cited by SBS assessed that Democratic control of Congress could complicate or delay South Korean corporate investments in the United States, as Democratic committees may apply greater scrutiny to deals tied to the $350B pledge and the Korea-US Strategic Investment Corporation.

07 | NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Dong-A Ilbo, China-Korea

North Korean envoy's Beijing visit fuels Kim Jong Un-Xi summit speculation

Seoul's Foreign Ministry assessed that North Korean envoy **Kim Sung-nam**'s third Beijing visit was aimed at sharing results of a Chinese party meeting and maintaining high-level exchanges, rather than primarily arranging a summit.

Foreign Ministry, China-Korea, Primary

FM Cho meets Canadian FM Anand; agrees to expand Canadian oil, LNG imports

FM **Cho Hyun** met Canadian FM **Anita Anand** on Nov 10 in Paris and agreed to deepen cooperation in energy, specifically expanding imports of Canadian crude oil and LNG, as well as AI, critical minerals, and defense, one month after a phone call between the two ministers. The two sides described Canada and South Korea as 'comprehensive strategic partners.'

08 | KOREA AND THE WORLD

Korea JoongAng Daily, Europe, Defense exports

Korea and Indonesia seek joint arms exports beyond troubled KF-21 partnership

South Korea's Defense Acquisition Program Administration held a Korea-Indonesia Defense Industry Cooperation Committee meeting on Nov 11, discussing localization, joint development, and joint export of defense products beyond the disputed KF-21 program, per JoongAng and DAPA readouts. The meeting follows a presidential summit that South Korean and Indonesian officials said elevated bilateral defense ties.

Defense Mirror, Europe, Defense exports

Poland receives final 2026 shipment of South Korean K2 tanks and K9 howitzers

Poland received its final 2026 delivery of South Korean K2 tanks and K9 self-propelled howitzers for deployment on NATO's eastern flank, per Defense Mirror. The deliveries are part of a multi-year framework contract that has made Poland one of South Korea's largest defense export customers.

09 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Bloomberg

South Korean battery makers face greater scrutiny in Hungary

South Korean battery manufacturers operating in Hungary are facing heightened regulatory scrutiny, Bloomberg reports, as European governments increase oversight of foreign-invested industrial facilities. The development is relevant to LG Energy Solution, Samsung SDI, and SK On, which have major European production investments.

LG Energy Solution | Samsung SDI | SK On

Dong-A Ilbo

South Korean firms win string of CES 2027 innovation awards

LG Electronics won eight CES 2027 Innovation Awards including a Best of Innovation honor for its LG SIGNATURE OLED T, the world's first transparent wireless television, extending LG OLED TVs' run of Best of Innovation awards to five consecutive years dating back to 2023. Samsung SDI and LG Energy Solution also received recognition for battery and software innovations.

LG Electronics | Samsung SDI | LG Energy Solution

10 UPCOMING

DEC 10

Korea Railroad Workers' Union begins indefinite general strike

The Korea Railroad Workers' Union announced an indefinite general strike beginning December 10 at 9 a.m., per Yonhap's headline summary.

11 ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun (@FMChoHyun), November 10

"I met with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio on the sidelines of the G7 Foreign Ministers' Meeting. We exchanged views on ROK-U.S. bilateral relations, high-level exchanges, and issues related to the DPRK. We agreed to continue working closely together to make progress on the implementation of the agreements reached by President Lee."

The bilateral aligns with the MOFA readout and State Dept press remarks, both citing North Korea and summit implementation as agenda items. **View on X**

President Lee Jae-myung (@Jaemyung_Lee), November 11

"Do not even dream of bid-rigging. The Korea Fair Trade Commission of the Republic of Korea, which makes it impossible to profit by breaking the rules, will continue building a fair market."

The post accompanied the record 1.6 trillion won fine on 15 bond-auction colluders announced by the Fair Trade Commission on Nov 11. **View on X**

Gen. Xavier Brunson (@CDRUNCCFCUSFK), November 11

"Each year, fewer Korean War veterans are with us to tell their story. This flag still can. Carried into the war in 1950, this original United Nations Command flag now stands at the U.N. Memorial Cemetery in Busan, near those who never came home."

Posted on Veterans Day; Gen. Brunson commands United Nations Command, Combined Forces Command, and United States Forces Korea. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

STATEMENTS

Marco Rubio

"We had a good G7 meeting, obviously hosted by some partners as well that came from Saudi Arabia and Brazil and Egypt and South Korea."

Rubio's public identification of South Korea as a G7 partner invitee follows the FM Cho-Rubio bilateral in which the two sides agreed to advance Lee-Trump summit implementation. **Source**

COMMENTARY

How Lax Enforcement in Laos Undermines Security on the Korean Peninsula. Young argues that North Korean IT workers operating from Laos, which is far more susceptible to US and ROK diplomatic pressure than Beijing or Moscow, represent a high-priority target for disrupting the DPRK's estimated $250-600 million annual IT-worker revenue scheme. The March 2026 Treasury sanctioning of Yun Song Guk, a North Korean IT worker unit leader based in Boten, Laos, is cited as a template for action. The piece connects to broader concerns about North Korean cyber capacity following the $6.36 billion Binance hack. (Benjamin R. Young, KEIA)

Trump Is Facing a Very Different North Korea. The Foreign Affairs piece argues that the DPRK Kim Jong Un now leads, with an expanded nuclear program, the March 2026 constitutional revision formalizing the two-state framework, and deep Russia entanglement, presents far more constrained diplomatic space for a potential Trump-Kim engagement than existed during 2018-2019. Trump's August 2026 Truth Social post announcing scaled-back US-ROK exercises, citing his 'very good relationship with Kim Jong Un,' is examined as a signal of the president's intent. The piece is directly relevant to today's NK News reporting on how Democratic control of Congress could limit any deal's scope. (Foreign Affairs)

One Year After Busan: Has China Kept Its Rare Earth Promises?. The CSIS analysis finds that Chinese rare earth exports to the United States remain well below levels recorded before Beijing imposed sweeping export restrictions in April 2025, despite the Geneva, London, and Busan Agreements intended to restore supplies. While China's overall controlled rare earth shipments have remained relatively stable, the selective reduction to the US and Japan suggests continued strategic discretion. With the broader US-China trade truce expiring January 10 2027, the report asks whether Washington can convert diplomatic agreements into reliable access or whether Beijing will continue weaponizing critical mineral dominance. (CSIS)

12 PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

0 pts vs Oct 13-15
Gallup Korea
October 27-29, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 7 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
35%	30%	28%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (October 27-29, 2026).

13 THE WIRE

DPRK

NK News

North Korea lists its Mexico City embassy building for sale at over $2 million

NK News confirmed the DPRK flag and identifying plaque were removed from the building's exterior and a for-sale sign now hangs above the entrance, though staff remain on-site and the mission is described as still operational. The move adds to a pattern of DPRK embassy closures and downsizing across Latin America and Europe amid sanctions pressure and budgetary constraints.

NK News

Czech Republic restores Pyongyang embassy, makes Karel Srol new ambassador

Karel Srol took up his post as Czech ambassador to North Korea in October, more than five years after Prague suspended embassy operations during the pandemic, making the Czech Republic the fifth EU member state to restore a diplomatic presence in Pyongyang. Srol paid a courtesy call on the Chinese ambassador to North Korea, Wang Yajun, upon arrival.

NK News

North Korean reunites with family member in South in first such case in two years

In April, the ROK Unification Ministry received a request through a North Korean defector from an individual in the DPRK seeking to locate an uncle living in the South, leading to a rare reunion, the first such case in two years. New data cited in the report shows over three-quarters of South Koreans separated from family in the North have already died.

ROK POLITICS

Yonhap News Agency

Defense ministry revises military academy merger plan; Army academy to relocate to Chungcheong

The Ministry of National Defense briefed lawmakers on a revised plan to relocate the Korea Military Academy to the Chungcheong region while retaining the Naval Academy in Jinhae and the Air Force Academy in Cheongju, backing away from the July proposal to merge all three into Daejeon's Jaundae compound. The revised plan adopts a 1-2-1 curricular model with shared first and final years at a joint academy, with implementation expected from the 2029 academic year.

TECHNOLOGY

Korea Times

Seoul pledges $20 million to ADB Korea AI for Development Trust Fund

The Ministry of Finance and Economy signed a contribution agreement with the Asian Development Bank at their annual consultation meeting in Seoul, pledging *$20 million* to the Korea AI for Development Trust Fund, which will support the Center for AI Innovation and Development to be established in South Korea under a May agreement with the ADB.

ROK ECONOMY

Yonhap

Ruling and opposition parties reach tentative deal to delay digital asset tax until 2029

A National Assembly finance subcommittee including lawmakers from both the ruling Democratic Party and opposition People Power Party reached a tentative consensus to delay South Korea's digital asset tax by two years to 2029, the fourth such postponement, per Yonhap. Finance Minister Lee Hyoung-il had proposed the two-year delay the prior week, citing preparation concerns.

14 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

New imagery reports, Nov 11

38 North publishes detailed analysis of North Korea's Choe Hyon surface warship and its strategic implications for the West Sea Fleet

38 North's analysis examines the Choe Hyon destroyer, North Korea's most capable surface combatant, detailing its weapons loadout including cruise missiles and its role within the West Sea Fleet. The piece assesses the vessel's strategic significance in the context of North Korea's accelerating naval modernization, which has included Kim Jong Un's Nov 7-8 inspection of a new warship under construction at Nampho Shipyard. The analysis connects to 38 North's Oct 30 report documenting public display of a vessel described as a 'Tactical Nuclear Attack' submarine.

Sinpo South Shipyard (activity/up)

38 North: Choe Hyon analysis

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinpo South Shipyard

As of May 2025: Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but was still not operational. New submarine construction begun in separate bay. NK Pro satellite analysis (Oct 20 2026) separately reports North Korea's Nampho Shipyard missed a deadline earlier in Oct 2026 to launch a 5,000-ton naval destroyer, with hull sections visible at two potential outdoor assembly areas. 38 North analysis published Oct 30 documents public display of a vessel described as a 'Tactical Nuclear Attack' submarine. Kim Jong Un inspected Nampho Shipyard on Nov 7 (reported Nov 8 by KCNA), announcing a new warship under construction larger than the destroyer built last year. NK News reported on Nov 6 that North Korea has expanded warship construction to a third shipyard. 38 North published analysis on Nov 11 of the Choe Hyon destroyer and its strategic implications for the West Sea Fleet.

imagery as of 2026-11-11

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North satellite imagery from October 16 confirms trucks traversing the New Yalu River (DPRK-Friendship) Bridge one day after the October 15 official opening, marking the start of commercial vehicle traffic. Daily NK reports (Oct 31) that North Korean trucks have still not joined Chinese cargo trucks on the bridge two weeks after the Oct 15 opening; North Korean transport officials are still preparing vehicles. North Korea-China trade reached $299M in September 2026, the second-highest monthly total in 2026. Kim Jong Un crossed the New Yalu River Bridge on October 24 during his unannounced visit to Dandong. Daily NK reports on Nov 3, 2026 that North Korea is courting Chinese investors to build hotels and shopping complexes in Sinuiju. NK News reports a surge in North Korean delegations visiting China, putting commercial ties in focus.

imagery as of 2026-11-11

9 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 231

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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